games anyway. I'd also run into one or two of the Real lads in the past. I'd gone out to Spain with some of the other United players in early 2003 to shoot a spaghetti Western-style Pepsi advertisement for television. All of us were dressed up like Clint Eastwood—stubble, leathers, the lot—on a set that had been built to look like Nowheresville in the Wild West. With a bit of help from a horse, I had a shootout and won against the Madrid keeper, Iker Casillas. Then Roberto Carlos, at the end, stepped out on the boardwalk with his hair cut into a Mohican—who could they have been thinking of—and gave me a look as if to say:

'If you want to talk about free-kicks, you'd better talk to me.'

When you're up against the likes of Raul and Zidane, Luis Figo and Ronaldo, there's always the danger of going out and playing against the reputation instead of against the player. Even at the very top level, you sometimes have to pinch yourself: you're not here to get these blokes' autographs, after all. We prepared well for the game in Madrid and trained at the Bernabeu late afternoon the day before the game. Even when it's empty, it's an amazing stadium. In the course of a training session you get what you never have time for in a game: the chance to look around and take the place in. I'd played there before but, that Monday, it got to me. The scale of the place, the sense of tradition: it's got an aura, like Old Trafford does. The history of half a century of great games, great players, success and silverware just seemed to hang in the early evening air. Almost as soon as we came off the field, I was on the cell phone to home:

'I've never had a feeling like that. The place is giving me the shivers. I can't wait for tomorrow night.'

After dinner that evening, we watched a video that our assistant coach Carlos Queiroz had put together. I think the idea was to make us think less about what a good team Real were and more about why we had a great chance of beating them: it showed highlights of the best things each United player had done in games during the season so far.

It was the right kind of inspiration and made us fancy our chances for Tuesday night even more.

I've talked to Mum about the game at the Bernabeu since. She was up in one corner, on the first tier, with all the United fans. She says she had the strangest feeling when we ran out before kick-off, which she never mentioned to anyone else: a cold tingle ran up her spine. She was convinced then that I would end up playing at this stadium for Real Madrid. For all the newspaper